LAF YOMI

Bekhorot 51 · November 08, 2026

ON TODAY'S DAF

Bekhorot 51 is all about what counts as payment for פדיון הבן: five selaim in Tyrian shekalim, the baraita's three coin-only cases, and the ban on slaves, shtarot, land and hekdesh. Rabbi vs. Rabbanan argue klal u'prat against ribbuy u'mi'ut; a shtar obligates but does not redeem; Rav Tarfon and Rav Chanina give the money back.

מצרפין שקלים לדרכונות · THE DIAMOND THAT WOULD BE EASIER TO CARRY



1. The mishnah lets cities combine their half-shekalim into big darconos — gold coins — so they don't haul sacks of small change up to Jerusalem. Less to carry, nothing to lose.

“So why not just buy one diamond? “Even though a diamond may even be easier to carry... No, it can only be a coin.” The Torah wants coins, not the most efficient asset.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 51a · מצרפין שקלים לדרכונות — combining shekalim into darconos · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 5:02

אין פודין בשטרות · THE CHECK THE KOHEN CAN DEPOSIT



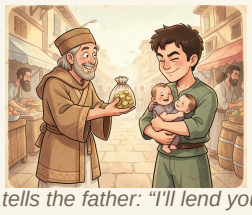
2. No pidyon with a shtar — a note saying Reuven owes Shimon money has no intrinsic value. But what about a check? The Chasam Sofer gives three reasons a check is fine.

“A check can't bounce — a check is equal to cash. Try the shopkeeper: “If you owe me money and I go to the store and I give the storekeeper that shtar... that doesn't mean anything to him.” The kohen can deposit a check — not your friend's debt.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 51a · אין פודין לא בעבדים ולא בשטרות — no pidyon with a shtar · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 7:46

כהן המסייע בבית הגרנות · THE KOHEN WHO LENDS YOU THE MONEY



3. A kohen wants the pidyon business, so he tells the father: “I'll lend you money, and when you have your son, you should choose me to be the kohen.”

“The Kesef Sofer says no — it's ribbis (loan repaid plus five selaim), a mitzvah haba'ah b'aveirah, and kohen hamesaye'a b'veit hagranot. The kohen may not buy the gig with a loan. (Gratitude, though — mutar.)”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 51a · אין פודין בשטרות — the kohen who lends you the money · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 10:25

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מנהגו של רבי טרפון · THE REFUND POLICY THAT CORNERS THE MARKET



4. Rav Tarfon's custom was to take the five selaim and give them straight back. The chachamim heard and said: he fulfilled this halachah too.

“But Tosafot is troubled: if Rav Tarfon always refunds, “everybody's going to choose Rav Tarfon to be the kohen” — isn't that kohen hamesaye'a b'veit hagranot? One answer: he only refunded fathers who couldn't afford it. Another: he never told them in advance.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 51b · וכך היה מנהגו של רבי טרפון — he took it and gave it back · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 34:37

רחש · THE WEALTHY RAV WHO WORKS FOR FREE



5. Rav Yitzchak Zilberstein: in Europe, rabbis, chazzanim and shamashim were paid per wedding — rachash. One wealthy rav said, “I'll be mesader kiddushin — baruch Hashem, I don't need the money.”

“He was told no. “Everybody's going to call him to do the mesader kiddushin and the other rabbanim do need the income.” Free is the most expensive price in town.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 51b · מנהגו של רבי טרפון — the free rabbi problem · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 38:16

שקיל ומהדר · THE FATHER PACING FOR HIS REFUND



6. Rav Chanina returned the money too. One father paced back and forth before him after the pidyon, waiting. “You obviously didn't give it to me wholeheartedly because you expect it back,” said Rav Chanina. “Therefore your son is not redeemed.”

“That's why the kohen asks at every pidyon: “מאי בעית טפי — what do you want more, your firstborn son or five selaim?” An old joke: a bechor who misbehaved, and the father would say, “I should've given you to the kohen.” No option — you give the money, wholeheartedly.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 51b · רבי חנינא הוה רגיל שקיל ומהדר — Rav Chanina took it and gave it back · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 39:04